

to suburbs on the outskirts of towns, far away from working-class areas, and live in single-family homes that were scaled-down versions of those inhabited by the nobility. For many middle-class women, such a lifestyle often brought with it isolation, which they often combated by taking on voluntary charitable work outside the home. In contrast, working-class households, while often densely packed and unhygienic, fostered more of a communal spirit.

Time to spend money

Consumer behavior was transformed during this period. Falling transport costs meant imported goods such as tea, coffee, and sugar became affordable, even for the working class. Mass-production techniques also lowered the cost of many commodities: after British ceramic firm Wedgwood used steam power to



◀ Luxury for the masses

Despite its luxurious debut in British society, tea became widely accessible to both the middle and working classes when prices fell during the 19th century. By this time, serving tea had become a woman's duty.

mass produce china, it went from being a luxury item to an everyday one. Shopping became a leisure activity for middle-class women who traveled to urban centers to view the latest merchandise; stores adopted colorful display windows and signs to attract them. Mail-order catalogs offering a range of goods—distributed by railroad and a reliable postal system—became popular, particularly for women in rural areas and African American women, who could order goods that they could not purchase in person from prejudiced store owners. Eventually, the working classes, too, were to take advantage of these new consumer methods.

